

Australia Daily Brief

Sunday, October 4, 2026

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RE: Albanese, Chalmers hit record poll lows · Fiji restores Great Council of Chiefs · Fiji seeks Australian uncrewed surveillance craft · Samoa PM filmed giving Nazi salute · Pre-COP31 opens in Nadi

ASX 200

8,682

+0.20%

AUD/USD

0.6957

-0.74%

NZX 50

13,680

-0.95%

NZD/USD

0.5623

-0.50%

IN THIS ISSUE [Top Stories](#) · [Overnight](#) · [Stat](#) · [Pacific](#) · [New Zealand](#) · [Canberra](#) · [Markets](#) · [Upcoming](#) · [The Wire](#)

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Labor's standing with voters has hit record lows as Jim Chalmers vows mid-year budget savings rather than new cost-of-living relief, then departs this week for Tokyo, Bangkok and Hong Kong.
- 2 Fiji's Parliament restored the Bose Levu Vakaturaga as a standalone institution outside the iTaukei Affairs ministry, while a separate constitutional amendment bill draws accusations of a democratic downgrade.
- 3 Pacific negotiators meeting in Nadi set red lines on climate finance ahead of Pre-COP31, with Fiji's climate chief saying the region would rather walk away than accept a weak deal.

• TOP STORIES

AU-POLITICS

Albanese, Chalmers hit record poll lows as cost-of-living bites

Anthony Albanese and **Jim Chalmers** have fallen to record personal lows in a new poll, with Labor losing its lead on every key issue except health, the AFR reports. Chalmers told the ABC's Insiders program the government will deliver billions in savings in the mid-year budget update, and downplayed the prospect of new cost-of-living relief. Labor holds 94 of 150 House seats and does not face voters again until on or before May 20, 2028.

per AFR: "Voters turn on Albanese and Chalmers as economic concerns bite" · also ABC News

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji restores Great Council of Chiefs as standalone institution

Fiji's Parliament passed the Bose Levu Vakaturaga Bill 2026 on Thursday, separating the chiefs' council from the Ministry of iTaukei Affairs. Minister **Ifereimi Vasu** said the institution's earlier removal had created a gap between the chiefs, the vanua and his ministry: "They were operating under the ministry, but now they stand alone." BLV chairman **Ratu Viliame Seruvakula** said recognition "is not an end in itself. It is a responsibility to serve."

per Fiji Sun: "Bose Levu Vakaturaga restored as standalone institution"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Fiji seeks Australian uncrewed craft to extend maritime surveillance

Fiji hopes to receive uncrewed surface craft from Australia capable of monitoring *up to 40 nautical miles* out to sea in any weather, Defence and Veteran Affairs Minister **Pio Tikoduadua** said. The craft would give the Republic of Fiji Military Forces all-weather maritime domain awareness. The disclosure comes as Fiji hosts Pre-COP31 delegations in Nadi and Tuvalu this week.

per FBC News (Fiji): "New craft to boost sea surveillance"

• OVERNIGHT

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Chalmers to pitch Australia as safe haven on Tokyo, Bangkok, Hong Kong swing](#) · SMH Federal Politics

Jim Chalmers will travel to Tokyo, Bangkok and Hong Kong to sell Australia as a safe harbour for investment amid global economic uncertainty, with a two-day Tokyo leg at the centre of the trip. The treasurer departs with his personal standing at a record low and trimmed mean inflation still above the Reserve Bank's target band.

AU-POLITICS

[Counterterrorism team probes flydubai co-pilot's Australian links](#) · ABC News

The Australian Federal Police confirmed the Victorian Joint Counter Terrorism Team, comprising the AFP, Victoria Police and ASIO, is investigating Australian links to a flydubai co-pilot who allegedly stabbed the pilot in an attempt to crash an aircraft on Wednesday. The jet, carrying 174 people and bound for Tel Aviv, plunged nearly 14,000 feet in under 30 seconds before diverting to Tabuk in Saudi Arabia. The United Arab Emirates is leading the main investigation.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

[Footage shows Samoan PM leading Nazi salute at 2007 family gathering](#) · Samoa Observer

Previously unseen footage shows Prime Minister **Laaulialemalietoa Leuatea Schmidt**, then deputy speaker, leading roughly 13 people in a stiff-right-arm salute and the phrase "Heil Hitler" at a family reunion in Safotu, Savai'i, in July 2007, the Samoa Observer reports. Historians and academics quoted by the paper raised concern, with one calling on the prime minister to apologise to those offended. The seven-second clip does not show what preceded or followed the exchange.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

[Fiji lifts security in Nadi as Pre-COP31 delegates arrive](#) · Fiji Sun

Fiji has stepped up its Police presence across Nadi for Pre-COP31, setting up checkpoints on Denarau Island and installing cameras at bus stops. Assistant Commissioner of Police Operations **Kasiano Vusoni** warned of motorcade escorts and intermittent traffic diversions between Nadi International Airport, Votualevu roundabout, Namaka, Wailoaloa Back Road and Denarau. Forums at five venues began in Nadi on Sunday.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Australian auction clearance rates fall to three-month low](#) · Bloomberg

Housing auction clearance rates across Australia slipped to a three-month low as borrowing costs climb, Bloomberg reports. The Reserve Bank held its cash rate at 4.35 percent on August 11, 2026, a second consecutive hold after three increases earlier in the year.

AU-DEFENSE

[Privatised US warfare reshapes assumptions behind Australian defence planning](#) · SMH World

A change in how America decides what future military power looks like transforms the assumptions around which Australian defence capability is built, the Sydney Morning Herald writes, with **Elon Musk** back in a White House role. Australia's announced trajectory is 3 percent of GDP by 2033 on the NATO-style measure used in the 2026 National Defence Strategy.

• STAT OF THE DAY

40 nautical miles

Range of uncrewed craft Fiji seeks from Australia

Fiji's defence minister says the all-weather surface craft would extend the Republic of Fiji Military Forces' maritime surveillance reach.

FBC News (Fiji)

• PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FIJI SUN

[Fiji warns Pacific would rather have no COP31 deal than a weak one](#)

Permanent Secretary for Environment and Climate Change **Dr Sivendra Michael** said Pacific negotiators meeting in Nadi on Thursday and Friday set best-case, worst-case and red-line positions, and that no decision "is better than a weak decision." He said *36 ministers and leaders* are arriving in Nadi and Tuvalu this week, and that the just transition mechanism cannot be separated from finance. Pre-COP31 runs until Thursday, ahead of COP31 in Antalya, Türkiye, from November 9 to 20.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

[Samoa sends parliamentary delegation to Australia, health team to Manila](#)

Samoa's Cabinet approved an official visit by a parliamentary delegation to the Parliament of Australia following an invitation from Canberra, led by Speaker **Auuapa'au Mulipola Aloiafua Mulipola**. A separate health delegation headed by Minister of Health **Va'aoao Salumalo Alofipo** will attend the 77th Session of the WHO Regional Committee for the Western Pacific in Manila from October 19 to 22, 2026. The Government Press Secretariat gave no further detail on the parliamentary visit's purpose.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

[Acting attorney-general defends constitutional bill against 'downgrade' charge](#)

Acting Attorney-General **Siromi Turaga** said the government is taking a "more transparent and engaging" approach to constitutional change, responding to the Centre for Democracy and Dialogue's description of the Constitution Amendment Bill 2026 as a "significant downgrade." CDD chief executive **Nilesh Lal** questioned who wrote the government draft and how a substantially different text was produced "in record time" after the Constitution Review Commission submitted its draft on August 31. A special committee has 30 days to review the bill.

TUVALU · FIJI SUN

Tuvalu appoints first female governor-general, drawing Fijian comparisons

Temukisa Auina Penehuro Hauma became Tuvalu's first female Governor-General on September 30, 2026, on the advice of Prime Minister **Feleti Teo**. Fiji Council of Social Services executive director **Vani Catanasiga** said Fiji had "a lot of catching-up to do," noting Fiji has five women among 55 members of Parliament and has never had a female prime minister or president.

REGIONAL · PNG POST-COURIER

Commonwealth opens second round of Blue Charter ocean incubator

The Commonwealth Secretariat launched the second round of the Commonwealth Blue Charter Incubator in partnership with the Prince Albert II of Monaco Foundation and CAF, the Development Bank of Latin America and the Caribbean. The programme funds ocean action proposals across Commonwealth member states, a grouping that includes most Pacific Islands Forum members.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fijian cane growers press government on \$85 price as costs climb

National Farmers Union president **Surendra Lal** said the \$85 per tonne cane price is "no longer sustainable" given high operating costs and the October fuel price increase, and called on Minister for Agriculture, Waterways and Sugar **Tomasi Tunabuna** to say whether an increase is under consideration. The Fiji Sugar Corporation's Labasa mill recorded a cane-to-sugar ratio of 9.1 to 1.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

National government gives K3 million to Wawin School of Excellence

Wawin National School of Excellence outside Lae in Morobe Province received *K3 million* from the national government for infrastructure development, the Post-Courier reports. The allocation follows a run of education commitments across Melanesia, including Solomon Islands' pledge of free universal education by 2027.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Immigration tribunal halts deportation of Samoan man over humanitarian grounds

New Zealand's Immigration and Protection Tribunal allowed a deportation appeal by a Samoan man in his mid-20s convicted of indecent acts against a child, finding exceptional humanitarian circumstances including his decade-long residence and marriage to a New Zealand citizen, RNZ reports. He was sentenced in 2023 to 10 months' home detention and 12 months' supervision for offending between 2018 and 2021. Deportation decisions involving Pacific nationals are a recurring friction point in New Zealand's relations with Samoa.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Shoebridge rules out 'blank cheque' for renewables projects

New Greens leader **David Shoebridge** said his party will give no blank cheques on renewable energy projects, The Australian reports. The position follows his party's leadership change and this week's reporting on an internal debate over whether the Greens should work with Labor or seek to replace it.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Hanson declares Victorian Labor 'finished' ahead of November state poll

Pauline Hanson declared state Labor "finished" in Victoria and promised a One Nation shockwave at the November state election, The Australian reports. The Australian's own commentary piece argues One Nation's "lock them up" messaging is no plan to govern the state.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Carroll pledges to unwind Andrews-era land tax ahead of Victorian election

Victorian Labor leader **Ben Carroll** vowed to unwind the land tax expansion introduced under former premier **Daniel Andrews**, The Australian reports. The pledge comes with the state election due in November and federal Labor's standing on economic management at a record low.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Firmus floats future Nasdaq listing alongside \$44b Australian IPO

Data centre developer Firmus told investors it could list in the United States to help secure capital for Asia-Pacific data centre construction, ahead of an Australian float the AFR now sizes at *\$44 billion*. The group priced shares last week to raise \$5 billion.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Private equity buyouts reach \$21b despite rising bond yields

Private equity bidding for Australian companies has accelerated to *\$21 billion* even as United States and Australian 10-year bond yields have risen, the AFR's Chanticleer column reports. Foreign bidders remain active in Australian assets, including the circling of leasing firm FleetPartners reported earlier this week.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Banks review property exposure as falling values squeeze small business

Australian banks are reviewing their property exposure as slumping house prices squeeze small and medium business borrowers who have pledged homes as collateral, The Australian reports. New Zealand house prices fell to their lowest level since early 2021 earlier this week.

• UPCOMING

OCT
19

77th Session of the WHO Regional Committee for the Western Pacific, Manila

Samoa's health minister and director general will attend, one of the few regular multilateral forums where Pacific health ministries set shared positions.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Marks the effective start of voting in a contest that will determine whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Decides the government that will set New Zealand's defence spending and Pacific policy for the next three years.

NOV
9

COP31 opens in Antalya, Türkiye

Türkiye will push a voluntary pledge to meet 35 percent of global energy demand with electricity by 2035, against Pacific demands on finance.

• THE WIRE

TRADE-ECONOMY

ABC NEWS

COP31 host Türkiye to push 35 percent electrification pledge

COP31 president **Murat Kurum** told the UN General Assembly in September that the technologies needed are largely available, as Türkiye prepares to push a voluntary pledge to meet 35 percent of global energy demand with electricity by 2035, up from 23 percent today. Outgoing UN secretary-general **Antonio Guterres** called this generation "the first with the tools to end the fossil fuel age."

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

NIKKEI ASIA

Nikkei's week ahead pairs Takaichi policy speech with Pacific climate summit

Japanese Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi** reopens parliament this week after her first cabinet reshuffle, with the Malaysian budget and the Pacific Islands climate summit also on Nikkei Asia's regional watch list.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FIJI SUN

Fiji police commissioner orders probe into officer in child assault video

Commissioner of Police **Rusiate Tudravu** directed the Internal Affairs Department to urgently determine whether a man filmed assaulting a young boy is a serving officer, and to ensure the child's safety. A police officer has been interdicted over an alleged serious assault of a child, according to the Fiji Sun's most-read list.

FIJI SUN

Fiji accepts Nasaulevu tourism master plan in principle

Fiji's Ministry of Local Government accepted the strategic direction of the Nasaulevu Integrated Tourism Development Master Plan in principle, handing a framework letter to the Nakovacake Development Trust. The ministry stressed the plan is not yet formally endorsed and that cadastral plans and technical documentation must still be assessed.

AU-POLITICS

ABC NEWS

Organised crime networks recruit international students to smuggle Australian reptiles

Dani Yannopoulos of the National EPA said serious organised criminal networks moving drugs, firearms and exotic animals are increasingly targeting international students on social media to carry native reptiles abroad. A 21-year-old man was charged in September over an alleged attempt to smuggle reptiles from Sydney to Hong Kong, and an international student was jailed for 18 months last year for trying to export 15 lizards to China.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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